

Introduction

For nearly 20 years, ThinkWorkStories! has been studying and developing stories about the practices and strategies that support people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) to live and work successfully in their communities. Many stories this year focused on the use of self-directed services to achieve competitive integrated employment and community life engagement.

Self-direction is a Medicaid service model that allows people with IDD to directly manage their own services and supports. Research shows that the use of self-directed services significantly enhances quality of life and offers an alternative path to achieving competitive integrated employment and community life engagement outcomes (Kulchinsky et al., 2021; Caldwell & Heller, 2007; Bogenschutz et al., 2019). Internationally, self-direction is viewed as a valuable service model due to its person-centered nature, individualized approach, and promotion of community integration (Bradley et al., 2021). In the US, nearly one-third of Medicaid Home and Community Based Services (HCBS) have the option for self-direction, which can include a range of employer authority (e.g., hiring and managing staff) and budget authority (e.g., managing HCBS funds; Friedman, 2024).

Although about 80% of states allow self-direction within their HCBS waivers for people with IDD, only about 13% of people with IDD nationwide self-directed their HCBS in FY 2021 (Friedman, 2024). This is despite Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS) (2014, 2019) urging states to expand self-direction and make HCBS more person-centered in alignment with the HCBS Settings Rule (CMS, n.d.). This results in missed opportunities to promote choice, individual control, respect, and self-determination, while ensuring full access to work, community involvement, and a fulfilling life.

The Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston conducted a qualitative study to learn about the experiences of individuals with IDD who self-direct their employment services. The study aimed to identify strategies and practices that have been effective in achieving employment outcomes. The study conducted semi-structured interviews with people with IDD, their family members, and supports brokers from different states across the country to better understand their experiences with self-directed services, resulting in seven individual ThinkWork! stories..

This brief is #1 in a series highlighting the self-directed services strategies people with IDD and their family members use. Brief #1 reports findings on seven promising practice stories about the use of self-direction on ThinkWork!. The findings highlight the benefits of self-direction, effective strategies for managing self-directed services programs, challenges encountered during implementation, and practical suggestions for individuals and families to consider when using self-directed supports.



Key Findings

The individuals with lived experience, their families, caregivers, and support persons provided a rich understanding of self-directed services and how they support competitive integrated employment. From a total of seven individual stories, seven distinct themes emerged.

Theme 1: Self-Directed Services across Life Domains

Participants used self-directed services for employment, transportation, and wraparound supports. Employment services included hiring job coaches to assist with job applications, interviews, and on-the-job training. At-home supports included assistance with household tasks, such as cooking, cleaning, grocery shopping, and other wraparound activities. Participants also used self-directed services to obtain assistive technology and transportation services, and to support self-employment, including help with business management, record keeping, scheduling, and billing.

Theme 2: Self-Directed Services Supports Autonomy

Participants shared that self-directed services gave them the freedom to choose who provides support, when, and in which areas of life. This gave them a say in their daily schedules and job choices, as well as the ability to arrange for the type and amount of support they needed for each part of their day. Therefore, they were able to shape their services around their unique goals and preferences. For example, one participant shared,

[Self-directed services] give us the opportunity to have more choice and control in our lives. I think a lot of things happen to us because of our circumstances, but self-direction gives us the opportunity to be planful and make things happen for ourselves...

Similarly, another participant explained that the use of self-directed services gives her a voice in making decisions about her support. She noted, “When I started using self-directed services, I really wanted to make sure I had a voice in the decisions being made about my support.” Describing what self-direction meant to her, she added,

For me, it means having control over how and when I use services. I decide who supports me and how. It’s about choosing what’s right for me and not feeling like I have to do it all alone... Self-direction lets me customize services, add what I need, and keep what works.

A third participant shared her appreciation of the freedom of choice that self-directed services provides noting, “I can do whatever I want... within budget!” She went on to say, “I love being independent and out in the community; [self-direction] is the optimal service to make it possible for me to do things I want to.”

A fourth participant spoke to the freedom that came when he shifted his service from the traditional model to self-directed services noting, “I’m 100% happy that... I have that control and that I have the support that I need because it...makes it easier for people with disabilities. It’s wonderful...I wouldn’t trade it for anything.”

Self-direction enabled people to customize their services and align supports with their interests and needs. Having choice and control empowered the participants to live more autonomously and allowed them to lead their lives on their own terms.

Theme 3: Self-Directed Services Leads to Strong Support Networks

A key benefit of self-direction is the ability to choose supporters you know and trust. Participants shared that self-directed services helped them leverage personal relationships, leading to more consistent, dependable, and personalized support. For example, self-direction allowed one participant to hire a long-time friend as a primary supporter to assist with at-home supports, transportation, and medical appointments as needed.

Similarly, another participant shared that he was able to hire staff he knew and trusted to set him up for success at his workplace. He hired his aunt as his job coach, and she supported him with his application and interview at the local supermarket. His aunt also provides on-the-job support. To ensure continuity, the family also hired a trusted family friend as a backup support. This participant reported that receiving consistent support from the same people enhances his work experience and provides the flexibility to take on additional shifts at work when desired.

Likewise, a third participant and his family shared that using self-directed services gave them the flexibility to hire staff who know him well and can support him effectively. His job coach has worked with him since childhood, originally working as a respite provider, and now brings a deep understanding of his needs and strengths.

The ability to choose supporters helped participants build strong and consistent support systems that promote their individual growth and achievement of goals.

Theme 4: Braiding Funds for Comprehensive Support

Braiding funding sources—such as Department of Vocational Rehabilitation (DVR), self-directed Medicaid funds, and informal resources like employer-provided supports—can offer people more comprehensive and flexible support in achieving their employment goals. Participants reported integrating multiple funding sources to expand available supports. For instance, one participant combined DVR funding with self-directed waiver funding to prepare for, secure, and sustain her role as a substitute teacher. Another participant combined his self-directed waiver funding with employer-provided assistance. Similarly, to ensure more customized services and supports, a third participant combined self-direction for his transportation services, DVR funding for his rehabilitation technologist at work, and independent providers for his homemaker and personal care supports. Participants reported that the ability to braid different funding sources helps them to get the right level of support.

Theme 5: Improved Quality of Life

Participants reported an overall improvement in quality of life through the shift to self-direction. For example, one participant and his family noted that self-directed services promotes person-centered planning. His father explained, “My son’s program is specifically designed for him. ... I think what’s working is he has the most person-centered program that you could wish for.”

Similarly, another family observed an improvement in overall quality of life. The participant’s mother shared:

His quality of life is so much better now because he’s more at ease.... He knows what’s going to happen for the most part during the day, or at least, he knows the person that he’s going to be with for that part of his day. He knows how he’s

getting home. He knows their name. It's a good feeling. I think, for a family who wants the flexibility and wants to know who's actually going to be working with their child, this [self-direction] is the perfect program for them.

These experiences highlight how the shift to self-direction can significantly enhance overall quality of life for participants.

Theme 6: Varied Management of Self-Directed Services

Participants reported using a variety of strategies to manage their self-directed services. Some managed core components, such as hiring staff and submitting timesheets independently. Others worked with family members or trusted supporters who assisted with budget management.

One participant reported working with a trusted circle of supporters—including family, friends, and coworkers—to conduct interviews, manage background checks, and handle the logistics of hiring. His supporters also provide input on how well potential candidates might fit with his existing team. Once staff are hired, he assumes responsibility for ongoing management, including tracking hours, budgeting, and providing raises and performance feedback. On the other hand, another participant independently completes and approves her staff's timesheets through a phone-based app and gets support from her family in managing her budget. A third participant used a different approach and worked with his family to submit staff timesheets and to manage his budget.

The different approaches to managing self-directed services show that with the right support and knowledge of available resources, everyone can use self-direction.

Theme 7: Challenges of Self-Directed Services

Despite the many benefits of self-directed services, participants identified several challenges in implementing and sustaining this model of service delivery. Some participants highlighted difficulties in finding reliable and consistent support staff. For example, one participant noted that staffing is more stable during the school year when college students are available to work, but it becomes more challenging at other times. Another participant shared that they initially struggled to secure consistent support when they began using self-directed services. To address this, they relied on their personal networks, often drawing on local college students in human services programs who were able to step in on short notice.

Another participant shared that he faced challenges shifting all his services to self-direction. He explained that existing providers often face barriers to getting approved as vendors through the financial management services system. As a result, he continues to work with his existing provider for some of his supports, while using self-directed services to purchase other services.

Notably, despite these challenges, all participants interviewed shared that self-directed services are worth the effort.

Strategies & Suggestions for People with IDD and Their Families:

- » **Start early.** Designing a self-directed service program takes time. Several participants noted that it took “trial and error” and several months to determine the kind of program that best fit their needs, and to put a solid program in place. It’s important to begin the process early, ask questions, and be prepared to adjust needed.
- » **It is essential to identify a support team.** Identifying a trusted team helps ensure the right balance of independence and support. The team can include family members, job coaches, friends, or service providers. Teams can help manage self-directed services by supporting hiring efforts, budgeting, helping answer questions, and/or assisting with decision making.
- » **Braiding funding allows for more customized supports.** Braiding funding sources, such as VR and self-directed Medicaid funds, can provide people with more comprehensive and flexible supports to achieve their employment goals. Using more than one funding source can help people get a wider range of support, from skills building and job applications to on-the-job training and coaching. It can also create a service plan and approach tailored to an individual’s needs and goals.
- » **Self-direction is possible for all.** Self-direction was reported as an option that provided participants with more autonomy over their services and circumstances. Self-direction gives added responsibility to the individual, with both employer and budget authority options. For some, this may be a challenge but supports are available to assist with making the program possible for all.

Conclusion

The findings from this study show that self-direction offers many benefits to people with IDD. It fosters greater freedom, choice, voice, flexibility, and control, and empowers people with IDD to design supports that fit their goals and enhance their employment and community life engagement opportunities. Further, participants reported an overall improved quality of life, noting that self-directed services allowed them to address broader issues like transportation and develop a trustworthy network of supporters. Self-directed services also provided participants with the opportunity to braid funding sources to expand their options. Lastly, the evidence shows that with the right support, self-direction is possible for everyone.

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